

Mountain kingsnake

Lampropeltis zonata

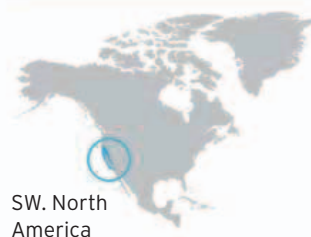
The California Mountain kingsnake has an extensive distribution from Baja California, Mexico, north into Washington state. As its name suggests, the Sierra Mountain subspecies (*L.z. multicincta*) is restricted to that area. Living in uplands and mountains up to altitudes of 10,000 ft (3,000 m), this habitat generalist basks by day in remote gullies or on old logs; rests at night among boulders or tree roots; and shelters in burrows through winter.

False colors

Like most other kingsnakes, this nonvenomous constrictor has red or orange, black, and white or cream rings that mimic the coloration of the venomous coral snake to deter predators. A stealthy sight-and-smell predator, it hunts mainly lizards and small snakes. Other prey include birds, especially nestlings of towhees and thrushes, eggs, and less often, small rodents, frogs and other amphibians. It may squeeze a victim in its coils to subdue it before swallowing it whole.



- ↔ 20–47 in (50–120 cm)
- ⚖ Up to 3 lb (up to 1.5 kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🐍 Small snakes, lizards, birds
- 🏠 🌲 🏔



SW. North America

△ TRICOLOR SNAKE

Ready to strike if need be, the Sierra Mountain kingsnake displays its bright warning colors. Not all of the subspecies are alike; some have thinner or even no rings.

The kingsnake **eats other snakes**—even venomous young rattlesnakes

Ensatina

Ensatina eschscholtzii

A native of western US mountain forests, the ensatina salamander does not breathe air. This nocturnal amphibian has no lungs—all the oxygen it needs is absorbed directly through its moist skin. The nostrils on the snout are used purely for smelling. Ensatinas have poison glands in their tail, but predators such as raccoons have learned to eat the head, then body, and discard the tail.

Mating occurs during the cooler seasons, and in summer, pregnant females retreat into a damp nook to lay a dozen eggs. The young hatch out after about four months and have the same body form as an adult, rather than going through a larval tadpole stage. They leave the nest after the first autumn rains.

- ↔ 2–3 in (6–8 cm)
- ☁ Spring and summer
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🐍 Worms, insects, spiders
- 🏠 🌲 🏔
- 📍 W. US



△ LIVING ON LAND

Unusually for an amphibian, the ensatina salamander's entire life cycle is based on land.

Yellow-legged frog

Rana sierrae

Found in and around mountain pools and streams, the Sierra Nevada yellow-legged frog lives at altitudes of up to 11,800 ft (3,600 m). It spends winters hibernating at the bottom of frozen lakes. In summer, it hunts by day, rarely straying more than a metre or two from water.

Three species of yellow-legged frogs have now been identified, all with a pale yellow underside. The main difference between the three lies in their distinct mating calls. The breeding season begins after the spring thaw, and after mating, the females lay their eggs on aquatic vegetation. The tadpoles take three or four years to reach maturity.



back legs
yellow
underneath

△ DEFENSIVE ODOR

Yellow-legged frogs exude a pungent garliclike odor from their skin if they are picked up.

- ↔ 2–3 in (6–8 cm)
- ☁ Spring
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🐍 Insects, spiders, worms
- 🏠 🌲 🏔 🌊
- 📍 SW. North America